The Private Chambers

Written by

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INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

Rain drums against the glass. The room is dark, the warm glow of a single bedside lamp that carves the dark.

MARA (23) is asleep, turned away from the light. She looks peaceful, the sharp edges of her daytime persona softened by the duvet.

CALEB (25) enters, moving like a ghost. He’s exhausted, his tie undone and hanging loose. He doesn't go to his side of the bed; he goes to hers. On the nightstand sits a weathered hardcover, bound in leather the color of a bruised plum: "THE PRIVATE CHAMBERS."

He picks it up, feeling the cool grain of the spine. Two bookmarks stick out from the top like small flags: his torn boarding pass and her dried lavender sprig.

He opens it to Chapter 8. Underlined in faint pencil is a single sentence:

MARA
"The hardest part of a secret is not the keeping of it, but the space it creates between two chairs.”

Caleb’s throat tightens. He looks at his boarding pass. He picks up a pencil and very lightly draws a small arrow pointing from her underlined sentence to the margin.

He writes:

CALEB (V.O.)
“I’m closing the space. Wait for me at Chapter 10.”

He slides his boarding pass three pages forward, lining it up exactly with her lavender. He places it on her side of the bed and clicks off the lamp, the room falls into a gentle, blue-tinted darkness.

INT. THE BEDROOM - THE NEXT DAY

The rain has stopped. High-altitude sunlight cuts sharp, dusty diamonds across the hardwood floor. The room feels like the inside of a tree, polished wood, amber light, and absolute silence.

Caleb is gone. The bed is empty on his side, the sheets tossed back. The smell of coffee drifts in from the kitchen.

Mara is sitting up in bed, wrapped in the duvet. She reaches for the book. She opens it and finds Caleb’s note. She touches the graphite of his handwriting with her fingertip and smiles.

MARA
(A raspy whisper)
You’re getting faster.

She flips the page, diving deep into the next section. She stops at Page 142, at a description of a sun-drenched garden. She grabs a vintage postcard and a pencil.

On the back of the postcard,
she writes:

MAYA
"Page 142. The description of the garden.
Does it remind you of the park on 4th Street,
or am I reading too much into this?"

She tucks both marks back into the spine, but she places her postcard five chapters ahead of his. A challenge. She closes the book and places it on his side of the bed.

She looks toward the door, watching the hallway where the sound of the shower has just started. She gets out of bed and walking off screen.

FADE OUT.